

Three Greek Philosophers: Plato, Aristotle & Socrates

Socrates

470-399 BCE

Core Contribution

The Socratic Method: questioning and dialogue to examine beliefs and reach truth through reason.

Key Ideas

Know thyself - Self-knowledge is the foundation of virtue

- Virtue is knowledge; vice is ignorance - He claimed to know nothing (Socratic irony) - Pursued wisdom through relentless questioning

Legacy

Founded Western philosophy's emphasis on reason and inquiry. Never wrote; his ideas transmitted through Plato.

Plato

428-348 BCE

Core Contribution

Theory of Forms: abstract, unchanging ideas (or "Forms") are the most accurate reality.

Key Ideas

The Cave Allegory - Most people see only shadows; philosophers see reality

- Eternal, perfect Forms exist beyond the physical world - Knowledge is recollection of pre-existing truths - The Good is the highest Form

Legacy

Founder of the Academy in Athens. Student of Socrates; teacher of Aristotle. Shaped 2,000+ years of Western thought.

Aristotle

384-322 BCE

Core Contribution

Empiricism: knowledge comes from observation and experience of the physical world, not abstract Forms.

Key Ideas

Eudaimonia - Flourishing through virtuous action and fulfilling one's purpose

- Virtue is a habit, developed through practice - The "Golden Mean" - virtue lies between extremes - Logic and systematic classification of knowledge

Legacy

Founded the Lyceum. Created formal logic. Influenced science, ethics, and metaphysics across centuries.